What's in the AI Rules for Students at UK Universities?

COMM5780M Week 4 Workshop: Imagining and Generating Data

1. Narrow Down the Idea and Define the Purpose

We started with the big topic of generative AI and university rules, and in the end we chose to focus on what universities actually tell students. Every university seems to have some kind of AI guidance now, but we noticed they don't all say the same things. So we picked 10 Russell Group universities and decided to look at their student AI guidance side by side, counting what each guide includes.

2. Discuss Ethical Considerations

We're only reading university webpages, so we aren't collecting anything about real people and don't need anyone's consent. We'll only use pages that are open to the public. If a page needs a Leeds login, or any other login, we'll leave it out. We'll also keep the link for every page, so anyone can check where our numbers came from.

3. Explore Data Sources

Mainly the AI guidance pages for students on each university's website. If a university doesn't have a separate AI page, we'll use the part about AI in its academic integrity policy.

4. Consider Data Gaps

1. From university websites, we can only see the general rules for the whole university. We can't see the specific rules for each course or module, which might be quite different.
2. We also talked about whether 10 universities is enough. For a small dataset it works, but it's only a small part of UK universities, and because they're all Russell Group, smaller universities are left out. So we can't say our results show what all UK universities do.
3. At first, we worried that many Russell Group universities might follow the same AI principles, so their guides could look very similar in our data. But our tutor told us that similarity is a finding, not a problem. If many guides are the same, it may show that universities are responding to generative AI in a similar way. If a university has an unusual rule, we will still point it out, because a number in a spreadsheet won't show what makes it different.

5. Select Data Collection Method(s)

We'll do it by hand, because every university's website looks different and a scraping tool wouldn't work well here. Each university gets one row. We chose things we can actually find and count on the page.

Variable	Value
Says students must tell when they used AI	0 = no, 1 = yes
Mentions AI checkers (e.g. Turnitin)	0 = no, 1 = yes
Number of allowed uses listed	count
Number of penalties listed	count
Year the guide was published or updated	year

6. Analyse Data Collection Impact

1. Because all our data comes from universities, it ends up showing their point of view. Universities make the rules and students just have to follow them, so a dataset made only from the rules can leave students out. It might also make the rules look clearer than they really feel to students.
2. As a data analysis company working with a UK university, we hope our data can help the university understand how other universities set their AI rules. With this, the university can give its students clearer guidance, so that students know how to use AI properly and fairly in their studies, without breaking academic integrity by mistake.